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LEVEL 1 · LEARNER MANUAL

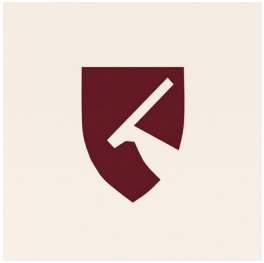
General Worker Safety Induction

Safety. Preparedness. Competence.

Author: Tangi Iigonda

Oryx Institute · Oryx Safety Academy

One day · Six modules · Certificate of Attendance



General Worker Safety Induction — Learner Manual

Oryx Safety Academy · Oryx Institute

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Welcome from the Principal

Welcome to the General Worker Safety Induction, the entry point of the Oryx Safety Academy. Oryx Institute exists to teach practical competence, not theory for its own sake, and safety is where competence matters most. Everything in this one day is built to be used the next morning on a real site, in a real kitchen, behind a real counter.

You will leave with a manual you can keep, a clipboard and pen to work with, and a set of habits, SLAM, TILE, hazard reporting, that take seconds to apply and prevent injuries that last a lifetime. Read actively, ask questions, and practise. Safety is a skill.



Tangi Iigonda, Principal and Founder, Oryx Institute

About this course

The General Worker Safety Induction is a one-day programme of the Oryx Safety Academy, the safety training division of Oryx Polytechnic Institute. It serves every new employee on any site: construction, mining, logistics, manufacturing, agriculture, hospitality and office work.

Field	Detail
Duration	One day (approximately 6.5 contact hours)
Audience	Every new employee on any site: construction, mining, logistics, manufacturing, agriculture, hospitality and office environments.
Entry requirement	Employed or seeking employment in Namibia; literacy sufficient to follow written safety instructions in English. No prior safety training assumed.
Assessment	Twenty-question written assessment at the end of the day. Pass mark 80% (16 of 20 marks). One reassessment is included in the fee.

Field	Detail
Certificate	Certificate of Attendance (internal record of completion — not an NQF qualification)
Materials	Printed learner manual, workbook, clipboard and pen, issued on the day and yours to keep.

Certification status, stated plainly: the Oryx Safety Academy is not yet a registered vocational training provider with the Namibia Training Authority and its certificates are not NQF qualifications. They are internal records that you completed Oryx training. Formal vocational programmes will commence only after NTA provider registration has been granted, and NQA accreditation for registered qualifications is being pursued in parallel and will be announced on the public register.

How to use this manual: each module states what it covers, its learning outcomes and key terms, then teaching content with worked Namibian examples, a learner activity and a knowledge check. The knowledge checks are for practice; the final assessment is marked separately. Bring the manual to every session.

Module 1 What occupational safety is and why it matters

Contact time: 60 minutes · *Oryx Safety Academy*

1.1 What this module covers

This module sets the foundation for the whole day. You will learn what occupational safety and health means, how harm happens at work, and why Namibian employers and workers each carry legal duties. The aim is practical: by the end you should be able to recognise unsafe conditions and unsafe acts as separate problems, and know that both are reportable.

1.2 Learning outcomes

By the end of this module you should be able to:

- Define occupational safety and health, hazard, risk, incident and near miss.
- Describe, in plain language, why workplace safety is a legal duty in Namibia and not only a company preference.
- Distinguish between unsafe conditions and unsafe acts, and give one example of each from your own work area.

- Explain the direct and indirect costs of a workplace incident to a worker, a family and a business.
- State who enforces occupational safety law in Namibia and what an inspector can do.

1.3 Key terminology

Term	Working definition
Occupational safety and health (OSH)	The field concerned with preventing injury and illness arising from work.
Hazard	Anything with the potential to cause harm.
Risk	The chance that a hazard will actually cause harm, combined with how serious that harm would be.
Incident	An event at work that caused or could have caused injury, ill health or damage.
Near miss	An incident that did not cause harm this time, but had the potential to.
Unsafe condition	A physical state of the workplace that can cause harm, for example a broken guard.
Unsafe act	Something a person does that can cause harm, for example bypassing a guard.

1.4 Safety at work in Namibia

Most working adults in Namibia spend close to half their waking hours at work. Over a forty-year working life that is a long exposure to whatever the workplace contains: machinery, vehicles, chemicals, heights, dust, heat and the pressure to finish quickly. Occupational safety and health exists because that exposure is predictable, and what is predictable can be managed.

The principal law is the Labour Act, 2007 (Act No. 11 of 2007). It places a duty on employers to protect the health, safety and welfare of their employees at work, and it places duties on employees too. The regulations currently in force are Government Notice 156 of 1997, the regulations relating to the health and safety of employees at work, made under the earlier Labour Act of 1992 and still applying today. A dedicated Occupational Safety and Health Bill was drafted in 2024 and is awaiting enactment; until it becomes law, the Labour Act and its regulations remain the framework.

Enforcement rests with the inspectorate of the Ministry of Labour, Industrial Relations and Employment Creation. Labour inspectors may enter workplaces, inspect records and equipment, and issue instructions. Inspector staffing is limited relative to the number of workplaces, so in practice most day-to-day prevention happens inside companies, not through inspections. That is one reason training matters: it puts the law into practice on the ground.

1.5 How harm happens

Workplace harm rarely comes from one dramatic failure. It usually comes from a chain: a damaged part, a shortcut taken under time pressure, a warning sign faded beyond reading, and then an injury. Safety professionals describe the sequence with two lenses. The first is the unsafe condition: the physical state of the workplace. The second is the unsafe act: what a person does or fails to do. Most serious incidents involve both, for example a missing machine guard (condition) combined with an operator reaching in to clear a jam while the machine runs (act).

Near misses are free lessons. A scaffold plank that drops past a worker without hitting anyone is the same event as a fatality, one metre away. Reporting near misses lets the employer fix the cause before the next occurrence costs a limb or a life. In this course you will practise writing short, factual near-miss reports.

1.6 What an incident costs

The direct costs are visible: medical treatment, compensation claims through the Employees' Compensation Fund administered by the Social Security Commission, repaired or replaced equipment, and lost production time. The indirect costs are larger and stay hidden: the injured worker's lost income while recovering, the family under strain, the crew that watched the incident and now works more slowly and more anxiously, the supervisor's hours spent on investigation paperwork, and the reputation damage when clients hear a contractor is unsafe.

For a small Namibian business, one serious incident can consume a year of profit. For a worker, it can end a career. Neither outcome is part of any job description.

1.7 Worked example

Worked example: A general worker on a residential site in Windhoek carries cement bags up a ladder all morning, then slips on the rung at lunchtime and fractures a wrist. The condition was a worn ladder and loose sand on the rungs. The act was carrying a load that blocked his view of the rungs. The near misses were the two slips earlier that morning that nobody reported. Each of those was a chance to stop the injury before it happened.

1.8 Activity and knowledge check

LEARNER ACTIVITY

Why safety matters to you

Write two or three sentences on a near miss you have personally seen or experienced at work or at home. Describe only the facts: what happened, where, and what could have gone wrong. Share with a partner, then agree on one thing that should have been reported or fixed.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

What occupational safety is and why it matters — check your understanding

1. In one sentence each, define hazard and risk.
2. Which law places the main duty on Namibian employers to protect employees at work?
   A. The Labour Act, 2007 (Act No. 11 of 2007)
   B. The Namibian Constitution only
   C. Company policy
3. A scaffold plank falls past a worker and hits nobody. This is best described as…
   A. Nothing, since nobody was hurt
   B. A near miss that should be reported
   C. A safe practice
4. Name the two lenses used to analyse how incidents happen.
5. Which ministry's inspectors enforce occupational safety in Namibian workplaces?
   A. Ministry of Health and Social Services
   B. Ministry of Labour, Industrial Relations and Employment Creation
   C. Ministry of Mines and Energy

1.9 Module summary

- Hazards have the potential to cause harm; risk combines likelihood and severity.
- The Labour Act, 2007 and GN 156 of 1997 are the current legal framework; a dedicated OSH Bill is pending.
- Near misses are reportable learning opportunities.
- Indirect incident costs usually exceed direct costs.

- The Ministry of Labour inspectorate enforces the law.

Module 2 Legal duties of employers and employees

Contact time: 55 minutes · *Oryx Safety Academy*

2.1 What this module covers

This module turns the law into a working tool. You will separate what the employer must do from what you as a worker must do, learn what happens after a workplace injury is reported, and see where the pending OSH Bill may take Namibian workplaces. The goal is that you can answer, without guessing, who is responsible for what.

2.2 Learning outcomes

By the end of this module you should be able to:

- List the employer's core safety duties under the Labour Act, 2007.
- List the employee's core safety duties under the same Act.
- Describe the reporting chain after a workplace injury, including the Employees' Compensation claim.
- Explain the difference between a safety instruction you may question and one you must follow.
- State two changes the pending OSH Bill is expected to introduce, and note that it is not yet law.

2.3 Key terminology

Term	Working definition
Duty of care	The employer's obligation to protect employee health, safety and welfare so far as is reasonably practicable.
Reasonably practicable	Weighing the risk against the cost and difficulty of removing it.
Safety representative	A worker elected or designated to represent colleagues on safety matters.
Employees' Compensation Fund	The fund, administered by the Social Security Commission, that compensates workers injured at work under the Employees' Compensation Ordinance of 1946.

2.4 What the employer must do

Under the Labour Act, 2007, the employer's duty covers the whole working arrangement, not only the building. In practical terms the employer must provide: safe premises, plant and equipment; safe systems of work, meaning written ways of doing hazardous jobs; the information, instruction, training and supervision workers need to work safely; personal protective equipment where the risk cannot be removed by other means, at no cost to the employee; and arrangements for emergencies, including first aid and fire response. Government Notice 156 of 1997 fills in the detail, from first-aid boxes to machinery guarding.

These duties cannot be contracted away. If a labour broker places a worker on a client's site, both parties still carry duties toward that worker.

2.5 What the employee must do

The law is two-sided. As a worker you must take reasonable care of your own safety and of others who may be affected by what you do; use the protective equipment and follow the systems of work provided; and report hazards, defects and incidents promptly. Reporting is a legal duty, not an optional courtesy.

There is also a practical boundary to understand. If you are instructed to do something clearly dangerous and outside any safe system of work, raising that with your supervisor or safety representative is the correct first step, in writing where possible. Deliberately ignoring a safe system, on the other hand, exposes you and others and can cost you the protection you would otherwise have.

2.6 When someone is injured

Report the injury to your supervisor or first-aider immediately, however minor it seems. The employer must record it and, where required, report it to the relevant authority. Injuries arising out of and in the course of employment may be compensated through the Employees' Compensation Fund administered by the Social Security Commission, under the Employees' Compensation Ordinance of 1946 as amended. The employer submits the claim; the worker supplies the facts and keeps copies. Treatment comes first; paperwork follows, but delays in reporting make claims harder.

2.7 The OSH Bill, pending

The Occupational Safety and Health Bill drafted in 2024 has not yet been enacted. As drafted it is expected to introduce, among other things, mandatory safety committees for larger workplaces and stronger duties around psychosocial risks, with heavier penalties. Nothing in the Bill applies yet. Treat references to it

as forward-looking, and check the current status before relying on any specific provision.

2.7 Worked example

Worked example: A cleaner at a coastal hotel splashes bleach into her eye while mixing cleaning chemicals in an unmarked bottle. Immediate duties: get her to the eye-wash or tap, report at once, record the incident. Follow-up duties: the employer must supply correctly labelled containers, decanting training and goggles, then submit the compensation claim if medical costs arise. If the employer had provided labelled bottles and training and she ignored them, responsibility shifts. Both sides of the law matter in the same event.

2.8 Activity and knowledge check

LEARNER ACTIVITY

Duty sorting

Your facilitator reads out eight short statements, for example “replacing a burnt-out machine guard” or “reporting a frayed extension cable”. Sort each one as employer duty, employee duty or shared. Where you disagree with another group, discuss why and record the reasoning.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Legal duties of employers and employees — check your understanding

1. Who pays for personal protective equipment required under the law?
   A. The employee, deducted from wages
   B. The employer
   C. Shared equally
2. Name the fund that compensates Namibian workers injured at work, and the commission that administers it.
3. Reporting a near miss is…
   A. Optional good manners
   B. A legal duty of the employee
   C. Only for supervisors
4. The OSH Bill of 2024 is currently…
   A. In force
   B. Pending enactment, not yet law

C. Repealed

5. List any three of the employer's core duties listed in this module.

2.9 Module summary

- Employer duties cover premises, equipment, systems of work, training, PPE and emergencies.
- Employee duties: reasonable care, use of protection, prompt reporting.
- Injuries flow through recording, reporting and the Employees' Compensation claim.
- The OSH Bill 2024 is pending; do not treat it as law.

Module 3 Hazard identification and reporting

Contact time: 70 minutes · *Oryx Safety Academy*

3.1 What this module covers

This is the core skill of the whole induction. You will learn a simple method for finding hazards before they find you, practise it against realistic workplace descriptions, and write a report that a supervisor can act on. Everything in the later modules builds on this one.

3.2 Learning outcomes

By the end of this module you should be able to:

- Sort hazards into the six standard categories.
- Apply the Stop, Look, Assess, Manage (SLAM) routine before starting a task.
- Write a factual hazard or near-miss report that names the location, the hazard, the people exposed and the suggested fix.
- State to whom a hazard report goes and what should happen next.

3.3 Key terminology

Term	Working definition
SLAM	Stop, Look, Assess, Manage: a routine for checking a task before and during the work.

Term	Working definition
Hierarchy of reporting	The agreed route a hazard report travels, normally supervisor, then safety representative, then safety officer or management.
Risk assessment	A structured judgement of which hazards matter most, done by the employer with worker input.

3.4 Six categories that cover everything

Safety training worldwide uses six buckets, and any hazard you will ever meet falls into at least one: physical (noise, vibration, heat, electricity, radiation), chemical (acids, solvents, dusts, gases), biological (bacteria, viruses, waste), ergonomic (posture, repetition, force, poorly set-up workstations), psychosocial (workload, bullying, fatigue, violence), and mechanical or safety hazards (unguarded machines, falls from height, struck-by and caught-between events, vehicle movement).

Sorting by category tells you what kind of control to look for, and it keeps reports precise. “Cold room was unsafe” helps nobody; “ice build-up on the cold-room floor, slip hazard, two workers” starts a fix.

3.5 SLAM: a habit that takes ten seconds

Before you start any task, Stop and think about what you are about to do. Look at the surroundings, including above and behind you. Assess whether anything there can hurt you or someone else. Manage: remove the hazard, guard it, or get help. Repeat the check whenever conditions change, for example when it rains, when a delivery arrives, or when you move to a new section.

3.6 Writing a report a supervisor can act on

A useful hazard report has four lines. What and where, stated factually. Who is or could be exposed. How serious the consequence could be. What you suggest be done. Write it the same day. Name people only as roles, not as blame. The report then follows the workplace's route: supervisor first, safety representative and safety officer next, and entry into a hazard register so it can be tracked to closure.

If you report something and nothing changes, you have done your duty, and the record shows it. Reporting again in writing is the correct next step.

3.7 Worked example

Worked example, warehouse: A packer in a Walvis Bay distribution warehouse notices pallets stacked six-high near the aisle where order pickers walk. Forklift brakes squeal. One pallet overhangs the stack. Using the categories, this is a mechanical hazard, struck-by, plus a physical hazard, noise. SLAM: stop, look up at the stack, assess the fall zone, manage by reporting and barricading the aisle until restacking. The report: “Row 14, pallets stacked to six with overhang above walkway; order pickers exposed; crushed-foot or head injury possible; recommend re-stack to four and strap, aisle closed meanwhile.”

3.8 Activity and knowledge check

LEARNER ACTIVITY

Hazard hunt

Working in pairs, use the hazard-hunt scenario sheet in your workbook: a description of a small bakery, a cattle post, and an office courtyard. Find at least six hazards per scenario, label each with its category, and pick the two you would report first, with your reason. Each pair presents its top two and the class agrees the best single report sentence for each.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Hazard identification and reporting — check your understanding

1. Name the six hazard categories.
2. What does SLAM stand for?
3. A truck reverses in a yard with no banksman and no reverse alarm. Which two categories does this fall under?
4. Write a one-sentence hazard report for a frayed extension cable in a staff kitchen.
5. Where does a hazard report go first in the standard route?
   A. The regional labour inspector
   B. The immediate supervisor
   C. The local newspaper

3.9 Module summary

- Six categories cover all hazards.
- SLAM is a ten-second habit before and during tasks.

- Good reports state what, where, who, consequence, suggested fix.
- Reports travel supervisor to safety representative to safety officer, and are tracked to closure.

Module 4 Personal protective equipment: what, when, how

Contact time: 55 minutes · *Oryx Safety Academy*

4.1 What this module covers

Personal protective equipment is the last line of defence, not the first solution. This module places PPE in its correct position in the hierarchy of control, then covers selection, inspection, care and the limits of each common item. The Namibian climate adds its own demands: sun, heat and dust.

4.2 Learning outcomes

By the end of this module you should be able to:

- Place PPE correctly in the hierarchy of control and explain why it sits last.
- Match common PPE items to the hazards they address.
- Inspect a hard hat, a pair of safety boots and a hi-vis vest for serviceability before use.
- Describe heat and sun risks in Namibian outdoor work and the controls that address them.

4.3 Key terminology

Term	Working definition
Hierarchy of control	The ranked order of controls: elimination, substitution, engineering controls, administrative controls, and only then personal protective equipment.
Engineering control	A physical change to the workplace or equipment that removes the hazard, such as a guard or local exhaust ventilation.
Serviceability	Whether an item of PPE is still fit for use: undamaged, within its life, correctly stored.

4.4 Why PPE is last, not first

Eliminating a hazard removes it for everyone forever. Substituting a less dangerous chemical does the same more cheaply. Guarding a machine protects every operator without depending on memory or habit. Administrative controls, like permits and job rotation, depend on people following rules. PPE depends on the right item, worn correctly, one hundred per cent of the time, in good condition, and it protects only the wearer. That is why the law expects employers to work down the hierarchy before reaching for a box of gloves.

When PPE is the remaining option, it is the employer's duty to supply it free, choose the right item, train users, and replace it when worn.

4.5 Matching items to hazards

Hard hats protect against falling objects and bumps, and expire: most shells carry a manufacture date and should be replaced per the manufacturer's guidance, and immediately after any significant impact. Safety boots protect toes and soles; steel or composite toecaps for crush risk, mid-soles for puncture risk from nails. Hi-vis vests make workers visible to plant and vehicle operators; they belong on whenever vehicles move. Gloves must match the hazard, because a rigger glove that catches in a rotating machine is worse than no glove. Eye protection comes in impact and chemical-splash grades; respirators come in dust, gas and combination classes and require correct fitting.

4.6 Sun, heat and dust

Namibian outdoor work adds ultraviolet exposure and heat stress to the standard list. Controls are administrative as much as personal: shaded rest areas, water within reach, task rotation through the hottest hours, wide-brim hats or helmet shades, long sleeves in light fabric, and sunscreen for exposed skin. Dust, from cutting brick and concrete to harvest field work, needs dust-rated respiratory protection and, where possible, wet cutting or extraction, which are engineering controls higher up the hierarchy.

4.7 Worked example

Worked example: A road-works crew near Oshakati works through the afternoon without shade rotation. By 15:00 one worker has a headache and has stopped sweating properly, an early heat-exhaustion signal. The PPE is all present and correct, which is exactly the problem: PPE could not fix a rota and water arrangement. The correct response is rest in shade, cool fluids, and a rota change; the helmet shade and fabric sleeves reduce load but do not replace them.

4.8 Activity and knowledge check

LEARNER ACTIVITY

Inspect before you wear

In pairs, take the sample hard hat, boots and vest provided. Inspect each for serviceability: cracks, deep scratches, the suspension, sole condition, retro-reflective strip condition, and the manufacture date where visible. Record your findings on the worksheet and mark each item: serviceable, needs cleaning, or replace. Compare findings with another pair.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Personal protective equipment: what, when, how — check your understanding

1. List the hierarchy of control in the correct order.
2. Why does PPE sit last in the hierarchy?
3. Which control is wet cutting of concrete blocks, instead of dry cutting with a dust mask?
   A. PPE
   B. Engineering control
   C. Elimination
4. Name two early signals of heat exhaustion.
5. A hard hat receives a significant impact but shows no crack. What should happen?
   A. Continue use, it did its job
   B. Replace it
   C. Paint over the mark

4.9 Module summary

- Work down the hierarchy before choosing PPE.
- Match each PPE item to its hazard; match gloves and eye protection carefully.
- Inspect PPE before use; replace hard hats after significant impacts.
- Heat and sun controls are mostly administrative: shade, water, rotation.

Module 5 Emergency procedures

Contact time: 55 minutes · *Oryx Safety Academy*

5.1 What this module covers

Emergencies compress every safety decision into seconds. This module makes the decisions in advance: what counts as an emergency, what the alarm sounds like, where the exits and assembly point are, who does what, and what never to do. Fire response is covered at awareness level; practical extinguisher use belongs to Level 2 and to qualified providers.

5.2 Learning outcomes

By the end of this module you should be able to:

- List the classes of emergency a Namibian workplace should plan for.
- State your own workplace's alarm signal, evacuation routes and assembly point.
- Describe the correct response on hearing the alarm, including the no-re-entry rule.
- Match the basic fire classes with the extinguishing media that suit them, at awareness level.
- Report an injury or emergency correctly, including who calls whom.

5.3 Key terminology

Term	Working definition
Assembly point	A pre-agreed safe location where everyone gathers to be counted after evacuation.
Roll call	The check against the attendance register or visitor book that confirms everyone is out.
Fire classes	The A to F grouping of fires by fuel: A solids, B flammable liquids, C gases, electrical involvement, F cooking oils.
PASS	Pull, Aim, Squeeze, Sweep: the sequence for using an extinguisher, taught practically at Level 2.

5.4 What we plan for

Fire, medical emergency, chemical spill, severe weather, and security events cover most realistic scenarios. For each, the plan needs the same four answers,

known by everyone: how the alarm is raised, how people leave, where they gather, and who takes charge. In a small workplace these answers take one page. In a mine or factory they take a formal emergency plan with trained teams. Either way, a worker who has never walked the evacuation route will not find it in smoke.

5.5 On hearing the alarm

Stop work, make your immediate area safe only if it takes seconds, for example setting down a hot tool, and leave by the nearest safe route. Do not collect belongings. Do not use lifts. At the assembly point, report to the person doing roll call so nobody re-enters to search for you. You never re-enter until the person in charge declares the all-clear. If you are trained as a first-aider or fire-team member, you carry additional duties; otherwise your duty is to get out and be counted.

5.6 Fire basics at awareness level

Fires are grouped by fuel. Solids, wood, paper, cloth, burn to ash: water cools them. Flammable liquids, petrol, thinners, paint, must not get water, which spreads them; they need foam, dry powder or carbon dioxide. Gas fires are controlled by closing the valve first. Electrical involvement means isolating the supply; dry powder or carbon dioxide can be used on live electrical equipment within their rating. Cooking-oil fires in kitchens need wet chemical or a fire blanket.

At Level 1 you must be able to raise the alarm, evacuate, and report. Handling an extinguisher competently is a practical skill, learned hands-on at Level 2 or from a qualified fire-training provider. If a fire is small, contained, and you are trained and confident, and your escape route is clear, the choice may be made to tackle it; otherwise close the door, evacuate, and let the fire service work.

5.7 Medical and injury emergencies

For a serious injury, the order is: send for the trained first-aider, call emergency services, give clear information, location, what happened, how many people injured, and stay with the injured person if it is safe. Every workplace must display its emergency numbers and the names of its first-aiders where GN 156 requires. Reporting the incident follows immediately after treatment.

5.7 Worked example

Worked example: The fire alarm sounds in a four-storey office block in the Windhoek CBD. A visitor starts towards the lift; a receptionist redirects her to the stairwell. At the assembly point across the street, the roll call shows one

person missing, a technician who had signed in but not out. Nobody re-enters; the fire team reports to the arriving service that the technician was last seen on the second floor. The missing person is found at a second assembly point. The lesson: visitors follow the person they know, and roll call only works if the visitor book leaves the building with the receptionist.

5.8 Activity and knowledge check

LEARNER ACTIVITY

Draw your escape

Sketch your own workplace, or the training venue, in the workbook. Mark your normal workstation, the two nearest exits, the assembly point, the fire extinguisher and first-aid kit locations, and the person who does roll call. Compare with a partner from a different area of the same workplace and note where your maps disagree.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Emergency procedures — check your understanding

1. Name the four answers every emergency plan must give.
2. You are at the assembly point and remember your phone at your desk. The alarm is still sounding. What do you do?
   A. Run in quickly for it
   B. Stay out and report to roll call
   C. Ask a colleague to fetch it
3. Which extinguishing media are suitable for a flammable-liquid fire?
   A. Water
   B. Foam, dry powder or carbon dioxide
   C. Any available
4. What does PASS stand for?
5. When calling emergency services about an injury, name three pieces of information you must give.

5.9 Module summary

- Every plan answers: alarm, exit, assembly point, person in charge.
- Leave by the nearest safe route; never re-enter before the all-clear.
- Match extinguishing media to fire class; practical use is Level 2.

- Give location, event and casualty count when calling for help.

Module 6 Manual handling and basic ergonomics

Contact time: 45 minutes · *Oryx Safety Academy*

6.1 What this module covers

More working days are lost to backs, shoulders and wrists than to dramatic events. This module covers the TILE assessment, the lifting technique that protects the spine, when to refuse and get help, and the small adjustments that make office work less damaging. It closes the induction content.

6.2 Learning outcomes

By the end of this module you should be able to:

- Assess a manual-handling task using TILE: task, individual, load, environment.
- Demonstrate the safe lifting technique for a moderate load.
- State the sensible cut-off for a one-person lift and the alternatives available.
- Adjust a computer workstation using a short checklist, and explain the purpose of breaks and task rotation.

6.3 Key terminology

Term	Working definition
Manual handling	Any transporting or supporting of a load by human effort: lifting, lowering, pushing, pulling, carrying.
TILE	Task, Individual, Load, Environment: the four factors assessed before handling.
Musculoskeletal disorder (MSD)	Injury or pain in muscles, joints, nerves, tendons, most often the back, shoulders and wrists.
Task rotation	Alternating tasks through the shift so the same tissue is not loaded hour after hour.

6.4 TILE before you touch the load

Task: what movement is involved, how far, how often, is twisting or reaching built in. Individual: are you trained, fit for it, appropriately clothed and shod. Load: how heavy, how bulky, stable, sharp, hot or slippery. Environment: floor condition, lighting, steps, room to set the load down. Any one weak factor changes the plan. A 25-kilogram stable box at waist height on a clear floor is one job; the same box at shoulder height up two steps is a different job needing two people or a mechanical aid.

6.5 The lift itself

Feet hip-width, one slightly forward, close to the load. Bend the knees, keep the back in its natural alignment, take the load with both hands, and let the leg muscles do the work as you straighten. Move your feet instead of twisting the spine. Set the load down the same way. The technique matters less than the decision before it: get help, split the load, or use a trolley whenever the assessment says the lift is wrong for one person.

6.6 Screens, desks and repetition

Office ergonomics is the same science at low intensity. Top of the screen at eye level, screen an arm's length away, forearms roughly horizontal, feet flat, thighs supported, document holder next to the screen for typing from paper. Glare from a window should be managed with blinds and screen angle rather than a twisted neck. Short frequent breaks beat rare long ones, and rotation between typing, calls and walking tasks spreads the load.

The same principle governs check-out tills, laundry folding benches, and packing lines: set the work at the person, not the person at the work.

6.7 Worked example

Worked example: A hotel laundry worker folds and stacks heavy bedding at a low bench for a full shift, then carries stacked piles to a trolley across the room. TILE shows the faults quickly: task includes sustained stoop and a long carry; load is bulky and blocks vision; environment makes the floor around the trolley cluttered. Fixes: raise the bench, stage the trolley beside the bench, smaller piles, rotation with machine-loading duties. Cost: a raised platform on castors. Alternative cost: her back.

6.8 Activity and knowledge check

LEARNER ACTIVITY

Lift, then judge

Using the practice boxes provided, each learner performs one supervised lift at waist height, then one from floor height, applying the technique. Observers use the eight-point checklist in the workbook. Then, as a group, judge two scenarios on paper, a 40-kilogram cement bag and a two-person awkward sheet of glass, and decide: lift, team-lift, or mechanical aid.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Manual handling and basic ergonomics — check your understanding

1. What does TILE stand for?
2. Which muscles should do the work in a correct lift?
   A. The back muscles
   B. The leg muscles
   C. The arm muscles
3. Name two adjustments that improve a computer workstation.
4. A task needs a 40-kilogram bag moved twenty metres. What is the correct decision?
   A. One-person lift with a straight back
   B. Team lift or mechanical aid
   C. Drag it to save time
5. Why are short, frequent breaks better than long, rare ones for repetitive work?

6.9 Module summary

- Assess with TILE before every handling decision.
- Legs lift, backs stay aligned, feet move instead of twisting.
- Get help or equipment rather than testing your limit.
- Fit the workstation to the person; rotate tasks; take short breaks.

Revision and next steps

Work through the knowledge checks again without looking back at the content, then compare. Anything you get wrong twice is your revision priority. The final assessment draws evenly from the six modules.

After the course, three things keep the learning alive: run SLAM on your next task; file one hazard report in your first week back; and walk your evacuation route once with your own eyes. Progression: learners who complete Level 1 and want formal responsibility for others may progress to Level 2, Safety Representative and Site Safety Officer, a five-day programme with practical assessment.

References and further reading

References follow a consistent author–date style. Legal references cite the jurisdiction, the short title, the year and the authority. Each entry below is also recorded in the Oryx Safety Academy Research and Reference Register with its reliability tier and review status.

[R1] Namibia (2007). Labour Act, 2007 (Act No. 11 of 2007). Windhoek: Government Gazette of the Republic of Namibia. Text available via the Legal Assistance Centre laws archive at https://www.lac.org.na/laws/. Accessed 2 November 2026.

[R2] Namibia (1997). Government Notice 156 of 1997: Regulations Relating to the Health and Safety of Employees at Work, made under the Labour Act, 1992 (Act 6 of 1992), as in force under the Labour Act, 2007. Windhoek: Government Gazette.

[R3] Namibia (1946). Employees' Compensation Ordinance, 1946 (Ordinance 36 of 1946), as amended, administered through the Employees' Compensation Fund of the Social Security Commission. See Social Security Commission, http://www.ssc.org.na. Accessed 2 November 2026.

[R4] Namibia (1994). Social Security Act, 1994 (Act 34 of 1994). Windhoek: Government Gazette.

[R5] Ministry of Labour, Industrial Relations and Employment Creation (2024). Annual report and staffing information, https://mol.gov.na. Accessed 2 November 2026. Inspectorate staffing figures quoted in the Oryx Safety Academy research dossier should be re-verified against the latest report before public use.

[R6] International Labour Organization (1981). Occupational Safety and Health Convention, 1981 (No. 155). Geneva: ILO, https://www.ilo.org. Namibia's ratification status should be confirmed on ILO NORMLEX before being stated.

[R7] International Organization for Standardization (2018). ISO 45001:2018 Occupational health and safety management systems — Requirements with guidance for use. Geneva: ISO.

[R8] Oryx Institute (2026). Oryx Safety Academy course pages, https://www.oryxinstitute.org/practice/safety-officer-course. Accessed 2 November 2026.

Legislative references must be checked against the official Government Gazette text before they are relied on. Where the legal position is uncertain, this manual says so rather than presenting an assumption as fact.

Glossary

Terms are defined as used in this manual. Where a term has a statutory definition, the statute prevails.

Term	Definition
Assembly point	A pre-agreed safe location where everyone gathers to be counted after evacuation.
Duty of care	The employer's obligation to protect employee health, safety and welfare so far as is reasonably practicable.
Employees' Compensation Fund	The fund administered by the Social Security Commission that compensates work-injured employees under the Employees' Compensation Ordinance, 1946.
GN 156 of 1997	The regulations relating to the health and safety of employees at work, currently in force under the Labour Act, 2007.
Hazard	Anything with the potential to cause harm.
Hierarchy of control	Elimination, substitution, engineering controls, administrative controls, personal protective equipment, ranked from most to least reliable.
Incident	An event at work that caused or could have caused injury, ill health or damage.
Labour inspector	An official of the Ministry of Labour, Industrial Relations and Employment Creation authorised to inspect workplaces and enforce the labour laws.
Manual handling	Any transporting or supporting of a load by human effort.
Near miss	An incident that did not cause harm this time, but had the potential to.
OSH Bill	The Occupational Safety and Health Bill drafted in 2024, pending enactment at the date of this manual.
PASS	Pull, Aim, Squeeze, Sweep: the sequence for using a fire extinguisher.
PPE	Personal protective equipment.
Risk	The chance that a hazard will cause harm, combined with the seriousness of that harm.
Safety representative	A worker elected or designated to represent colleagues on safety matters.

Term	Definition
SLAM	Stop, Look, Assess, Manage: a routine for checking a task before and during the work.
TILE	Task, Individual, Load, Environment: the four factors assessed before manual handling.
Unsafe act	Something a person does that can cause harm.
Unsafe condition	A physical state of the workplace that can cause harm.

Feedback and support

Your evaluation form at the end of the day feeds directly into course review. If anything in this manual appears incorrect or unclear, tell us on the day or write to info@oryxinstitute.org. Corrections are logged, reviewed and credited.